



New concept: "You are comparing very different elements with each other. We don't have anything like this where you just form a new team, buy some players and start" - Hyderabad Toofans coach Gademan on the Hockey India League. HOCKEYINDIA

medallist, and Terrance Pieters, the first player of colour to represent the Netherlands national team.

He credits Verga, the former Argentine international who had coached him throughout his playing career, as his biggest influence in hockey.

"The man is so passionate, always giving his heart and soul to the project. I really admired that; something about the way he did it inspired me and gave me strength in all aspects of my life," he says.

But most importantly, it was Gademan's love for hockey and creating a culture that shaped his journey. This began in Almere, where his "real journey" started at just three years old. His parents, both political activists who fought against the Islamist regime in Iran,

MY MOTHER IS NOW A PUBLIC FIGURE IN THE NETHERLANDS, BUT SHE WAS IMPRISONED FROM A YOUNG AGE IN IRAN FOR POLITICAL REASONS. IT WAS EXTREMELY DIFFICULT FOR OUR FAMILY – 'DIFFICULT' IS A SOFT WORD. IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE FOR US TO LIVE THERE

were forced to seek asylum in the Netherlands.

The Iranian Revolution of 1979 led to the overthrow of Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi and the establishment of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The new regime curbed the rights of the Iranian people, prompting Gademan's parents to campaign for freedom rights.